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PERSONALITY DIFFERENCES IN EFFECTIVENESS OF EMOTION REGULATION FOLLOWING AUTOBIOGRAPHICAL RECOLLECTION OF TRAUMA

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Abstract – In this study, we tested the relationship between personality traits and effectiveness of emotion regulation following recall of a traumatic memory. We focused on the emotion regulation strategy known as cognitive reappraisal, a process of reinterpreting distressing events to reduce their negative emotional effects. Participants wrote about a past traumatic event and were then randomly assigned to one of two conditions. In the experimental condition, they were instructed to execute cognitive reappraisal to downregulate negative emotions tied to the memory. In the control condition, they simply recalled their past emotions associated with the memory. Supporting our hypotheses, persons high in conscientiousness and high in openness to experience reported less negative affect following the recall and reappraisal tasks. Overall, persons high in neuroticism reported more negative affect, irrespective of experimental condition. Our findings suggest that although reappraisal can be an effective approach for many individuals, it may be less advantageous for persons with particular personality profiles. Future research should investigate the value of alternate emotion regulation approaches to meet the needs of persons with different personalities.

Keywords: emotion regulation, personality, trauma

Emotion regulation is a goal-directed process whereby people manage their emotional states (Gross, 1998). This is essential for social competence and psychological well-being, particularly following adversity (Hughes et. al 2020; Baranczuk, 2019). Emotion regulation occurs both consciously and unconsciously, and emotion regulation strategies can be healthy or unhealthy. For example, evidence suggests a strategy such as suppression (i.e., intentionally ignoring emotions) to be effective in regulating negative affect but can be harmful to memory (Kobylińska et. al, 2020). Effective and healthy emotion regulation is imperative to retain the beneficial qualities of emotion while limiting the destructive qualities (John & Gross, 2004). One emotion regulation strategy that has received a great deal of research attention and is associated with adaptive coping is cognitive reappraisal (John & Gross, 2004). This involves reinterpreting an emotionally charged event to alter its impact (Gross & John, 2003). Empirical evidence has suggested that reappraisal is an effective strategy to downregulate negative emotions such as stress, disgust, sadness, and fear (John & Gross, 2004) and has been linked to greater experience of positive emotion and diminished experience of negative emotion (Gross & John, 2003) as well as enhanced long-term wellness (Troy et. al, 2018).

Reappraisal has been described as an effortful process that requires skill as well as motivation, conviction and a belief that emotions can be altered (Gutentag et al, 2016). Detailed investigations of the reappraisal process indicate that it requires cognitive processes including memory, restructuring, and task switching (Troy et. al, 2018; Vaughn-Johnston et. al, 2020). Past research suggests that individuals differ in their trait-like tendency to utilize cognitive reappraisal (Gross & John 2003). The Emotion Regulation Questionnaire (Gross & John, 2003) was developed to measure these individual differences. Research has shown that greater tendency to utilize cognitive appraisal is associated with more resilience in response to life stress (Garnefski et al., 2001), reduced psychological distress (Aldao et al., 2010; De France, 2022) and greater overall psychological well-being (Riepenhausen et al., 2022).

There is also evidence that tendencies to use specific emotion regulation strategies are linked to stable individual differences in personality. These personality differences have been investigated through the lens of the Big Five Factor theory of personality (Costa & McCrae, 1992; McCrae & Costa, 2008). This paradigm is widely used in personality research, clinical practice, and related fields (John & Srivastava, 1999). This model suggests that individual differences in personality can be categorized into five main dimensions that include openness to experience, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism (McCrae & Costa, 2008). In-depth exploration of the dimension of agreeableness indicates that agreeableness taps a person's level of cooperation, empathy, and concern for others (Costa et al., 1991). Whereas the dimension of conscientiousness reflects a person's degree of achievement-striving, self-discipline, responsibility, and deliberation (Costa et al., 1991). The openness dimension has been characterized as an individual's willingness to experience new ideas, feelings, and behaviors (McCrae & Costa, 1997). Extraversion has been found to reflect an individual's level of social interaction, assertiveness, and positive emotionality (Watson & Clark, 1997). Finally, neuroticism reflects a person's emotional instability, and tendency to experience negative emotions (Costa & McCrae, 1980) as well as vulnerability to stress due to ineffective coping (McCrae & Costa, 1986).

A recent meta-analytic review (Barańczuk, 2019) found associations between each of the big five factors and tendencies to utilize emotion regulation strategies. Specifically, the meta-analysis revealed associations between a tendency to utilize maladaptive emotion regulation strategies such as suppression or avoidance with higher levels of neuroticism and lower levels of extraversion, openness to experience, agreeableness, and conscientiousness. Conversely, a tendency to utilize adaptive emotion regulation strategies such as reappraisal or problem solving was associated with lower levels of neuroticism and higher levels of openness to experience, conscientiousness, agreeableness, and extraversion.

To expand on the aforementioned findings concerning differences in *tendency* to utilize emotion regulation strategies, we sought to investigate the extent to which personality differences might be tied to differential *ability* to effectively leverage emotion regulation. To investigate this question, we focused specifically on differences in effective use of cognitive reappraisal. Our study's aim was to investigate the impact of personality on the effectiveness of attempts to use reappraisal to manage negative emotions associated with autobiographical recollections of trauma. We expected that three of the big five factor dimensions would be particularly relevant to individual differences in the ability to execute this emotion regulation strategy to downregulate negative emotions. Because reappraisal is an effortful process that requires deliberate cognitive effort (Gutentag et al, 2016), we expected it to be impacted by the trait of conscientiousness, which involves a willingness to exert effort (Bidjerano & Dai, 2007) and a tendency toward deliberate thinking (Costa et al., 1991). We therefore hypothesized that those high in conscientiousness would be more successful in lowering negative affect through cognitive reappraisal. Furthermore, because reappraisal involves cognitive restructuring (Vaughn-Johnston et. al, 2020), we expected it to be facilitated by an ability to see multiple perspectives. This flexibility in thinking is characteristic of the trait of openness to experience (Chamorro-Premuzic et al., 2007). We therefore hypothesized that those high in openness would be more successful in reducing negative affect through cognitive reappraisal. Finally, reappraisal is influenced by perceptions that emotions are controllable (Gutentag et al., 2016). Persons high in the trait of neuroticism tend to lack efficacy in managing negative emotions (Cheng, 2001). We therefore expected that those low in the trait of neuroticism would be more likely to invest effort in reappraisal due to greater optimism about managing negative affect. Consequently, we hypothesized that persons low, versus high, in neuroticism would be more successful in lowering negative affect through use of reappraisal.

Method

Participants

The participants were 105 adults with a mean age of 21 years (*SD*=5.4) who were recruited from college classrooms and completed the study. The majority identified as female (67%), while 21% identified as male, 1 % identified as transgender male, 1% identified as transgender female and 2% identified as “other”. The majority of participants were white (64%), while 29% were Black, 4% were Hispanic/Latino, 2% were Asian and 1% were Middle Eastern. Furthermore, 67% percent identified as heterosexual, 20% as bisexual, 7% as homosexual and 6% identified as “other”

Procedure and Materials

Trauma Recollection and Ratings

Participants were tested in a group setting. After reading the informed consent form and agreeing to take part, they were asked to recall and briefly write about an adverse/traumatic event. They then completed two items based on the procedure followed by Troy et al., (2018).

First, they rated the extent to which the event they recalled was stressful. These ratings were made on a Likert scale ranging from 1 (not at all) to 10 (to an extreme degree). Next, they rated the extent to which the recalled event has a current negative impact in their lives. These ratings were made on a Likert scale ranging from 1 (not at all) to 10 (to an extreme degree).

Manipulation of Emotion Regulation

Next, participants were randomly assigned to one set of instructions for the emotion regulation task, based on Troy et al., (2018). For the reappraisal condition, participants were asked to try to think about the previously recalled event in a more favorable light and briefly describe any positive effects of the event, such as what they may have learned or how the event had a positive influence on their life. They were asked to write those positive thoughts in the space provided on the paper. For the control condition, participants were asked to think about and briefly describe the feelings evoked by the recalled event in the space provided.

Affect Ratings

After completing the brief writing task, participants were asked to complete a series of emotion ratings, based on Troy et al., (2018). Specifically, they rated the extent to which they were feeling 7 different negative emotions, ranging from "hopelessness" to "anger". Ratings were made on a Likert response scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). A composite negative affect score was obtained by summing and averaging responses to the 7 emotion ratings. Cronbach's α for this measure was .87, suggesting acceptable internal reliability.

Personality Assessment

To measure the traits of conscientiousness, openness and neuroticism, participants were asked to respond to the corresponding subscales of The Big Five Inventory (John & Srivastava, 1999). All responses were made using a Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Participants responded to the conscientiousness subscale by rating their agreement with 9 items such as "does a thorough job" and "is a reliable worker". We obtained a Cronbach's α score of .81 for this subscale, indicating acceptable internal reliability. Participants responded to the openness subscale by rating their agreement with 10 items such as "is original, comes up with new ideas" and "has an active imagination". We obtained a Cronbach's α score of .76 for this subscale, suggesting acceptable internal reliability. Participants responded to the neuroticism subscale by indicating their agreement with 8 items such as "can be tense" or "can be moody". Cronbach's α for this measure was .83, suggesting acceptable internal reliability.

Demographics

Finally, participants were asked to respond to commonly used demographic items (e.g., age, gender, race).

Results

Participants' mean rating of stress caused by their recalled event was 8.5 (*SD* = 1.5). Their average rating of current impact for the recalled event was 6.67 (*SD* = 2.5). The mean negative affect score was 3.06 (*SD* =.9). The mean for the conscientiousness subscale of The Big Five Inventory (John & Srivastava, 1999) was 3.33 (*SD* = .6). Participants scoring above the average were categorized as high in conscientiousness and those scoring below the average were categorized as low in conscientiousness. The mean for the openness to experience subscale of The Big Five Inventory (John & Srivastava, 1999) was 3.61 (*SD* = .5). Participants scoring above the average were categorized as high in openness and those scoring below the average were categorized as low in openness. The mean for the neuroticism subscale of The Big Five Inventory (John & Srivastava, 1999) was 3.43 (*SD* =.7). Participants scoring above the average were categorized as high in neuroticism and those scoring below the average were categorized as low in neuroticism.

No statistically significant differences were found across our variables of interest as a function of demographics and thus, they will not be discussed in the results section.

Negative Affect as a Function of Emotion Regulation and Personality

A 2x2 between groups ANOVA yielded a nonsignificant main effect for Conscientiousness on negative affect $F(1, 101) = 2.48$, $p = .12$ and a nonsignificant main effect for Emotion Regulation condition on negative affect, $F(1, 101) = 3.42$, $p = .07$. The analysis also yielded the predicted significant interaction between Conscientiousness and Emotion Regulation condition on negative affect, $F(1, 101) = 4.374$, $p = .04$. Post-hoc LSD pairwise comparisons revealed that those high in Conscientiousness had lower negative affect in the Reappraisal condition versus the Control condition ($p = .01$). However, no significant differences were found across conditions for those low in Conscientiousness ($p = .87$). See Table 1 for means and standard deviations.

Table 1
Means and Standard Deviations for Negative Affect Across Emotion Regulation Conditions and Conscientiousness Conditions.

	Control	Reappraisal
Low Conscientiousness	3.17 (.76) [a]	3.20 (.91) [a]
High Conscientiousness	3.21 (.70) [a]	2.90 (1.0) [b]

Note. Means with different superscripts are statistically different, $p < .01$.

In addition, a 2x2 between groups ANOVA yielded a significant main effect for Openness to Experience on negative affect $F(1, 101) = 8.26$, $p = .01$ and a nonsignificant main effect for Emotion Regulation condition on negative affect, $F(1, 101) = 2.81$, $p = .10$. The analysis also yielded the predicted significant interaction between Openness to Experience and Emotion Regulation condition on negative affect, $F(1, 101) = 6.07$, $p = .02$. Post- hoc LSD pairwise comparisons revealed that those high in Openness had lower negative affect in the Reappraisal condition versus the Control condition ($p = .01$). However, no significant differences were found across conditions for those low in Openness ($p = .57$). See Table 2 for means and standard deviations.

Table 2
Means and Standard Deviations for Negative Affect Across Emotion Regulation Conditions and Openness Conditions.

	Control	Reappraisal
Low Openness	3.24 (.56)[a]	3.37 (.88)[a]
High Openness	3.17 (.86)[a]	2.51 (.94)[b]

Note. Means with different superscripts are statistically different, $p < .01$.

Finally, a 2x2 between groups ANOVA yielded a significant main effect for Neuroticism on negative affect $F(1, 101) = 12.81$, $p = .001$ and a significant main effect for Emotion Regulation condition on negative affect, $F(1, 101) = 3.82$, $p = .05$. The analysis also revealed that the interaction between Neuroticism and Emotion Regulation condition on negative affect did not reach statistical significance, $F(1, 101) = 3.45$, $p = .07$. See Table 3 for means and standard deviations.

Table 3
Means and Standard Deviations for Negative Affect Across Emotion Regulation Conditions and Neuroticism Conditions.

	Control	Reappraisal
Low Openness	3.10 (.67)	2.49 (.76)
High Openness	3.37 (.72)	3.35 (1.06)

Discussion

The aim of our study was to test the relationship between personality traits and the ability to effectively leverage cognitive reappraisal to downregulate negative affect following recall of a traumatic memory. Our findings suggest that although reappraisal can be an effective approach for many individuals, it may be less advantageous for persons low in conscientiousness and those low in openness.

Supporting our first hypothesis, participants high (versus low) in conscientiousness who were instructed to leverage cognitive reappraisal after writing about prior trauma reported less negative affect. This suggests they were better able to effectively leverage reappraisal to regulate unpleasant emotions that may have been activated during the recall task. This finding may be explained by the fact that conscientiousness is a trait associated with self-control and goal-directed behavior (DeYoung, 2015; John & Srivastava, 1999). These tendencies are likely to facilitate the process of cognitive reappraisal, which requires self-regulation and investment in effortful thinking (Gross, 2015).

Supporting our second hypothesis, participants high (versus low) in openness to experience reported less negative affect following the recall and reappraisal tasks. This suggests that similar to those high in conscientiousness, they were better able to effectively execute reappraisal to regulate negative emotions tied to their recall of trauma. Openness to experience is a trait associated with curiosity, creativity, and flexible thinking (DeYoung, 2015; John & Srivastava, 1999). Cognitive reappraisal is likely facilitated by these tendencies, as it requires the generation of novel and flexible interpretations of situations (Gross, 2015).

With respect to our final hypothesis, although participants low (versus high) in neuroticism reported less negative affect following the recall and reappraisal tasks, this difference did not reach statistical significance. However, we found a significant main effect for neuroticism on negative affect. Irrespective of whether they were in the reappraisal condition or the control condition, those high in neuroticism reported more negative affect. This suggests that the overall influence of neuroticism on the experience of negative emotions was rather powerful. These results are consistent with prior research that suggests individuals high in neuroticism tend to lack confidence in their ability to manage negative emotions (Cheng, 2001).

Theoretical Implications

Overall, our study adds to the existing literature by highlighting the importance of considering personality traits as a key factor in predicting the *ability* to effectively employ specific emotion regulation strategies. This expands on previous research showing that personality traits are associated with differential *tendencies* to utilize emotion regulation strategies (Barańczuk, 2019). In particular, we found evidence that cognitive reappraisal, which involves generating alternative interpretations of situations, requires cognitive flexibility and investment of effort, may not be equally advantageous for everyone. Specifically, our results suggest that individuals low in

conscientiousness and low in openness to experience may experience less benefit from cognitive reappraisal as a tool for regulating emotion. This implies that individuals with these personality traits may need to rely on alternative strategies to effectively regulate their emotions. By considering these individual differences, we enhance our understanding of emotion regulation processes.

Practical Implications

Our findings have practical implications as well. Individuals who have difficulty regulating negative affect after adverse life experiences are more vulnerable to onset of mental health conditions such as depression (Hammen, 2005). There is evidence that a large percentage of adults report a history of past traumatic events (Benjet et. al., 2016). For those who struggle with negative emotions tied to their past adverse events, discovery of effective coping strategies is important. Understanding the factors influencing the effectiveness of emotion regulation strategies can help identify efficacious interventions suited to the needs of individuals. Future research should investigate the value of alternate emotion regulation approaches (e.g., acceptance, suppression) for persons with different personality profiles.

Limitations

This study was subject to limitations. The first of these is an absence of diversity in the sample, as the majority of participants were college-aged, white females. This outcome reflects the campus population where the study was conducted and limits the generalizability of findings. Future researchers should actively broaden the scope of gender, age, and race when testing similar research questions. Another potential limitation of our study is the method we used (similar to a median split) to categorize participants as high or low in conscientiousness, openness and neuroticism. We may have obtained more robust effects if we had a large enough sample to utilize upper and lower quadrants to categorize our participants into the different personality groupings. Another limitation of our findings is that we focused on one emotion regulation strategy (cognitive reappraisal). Future researchers should explore whether the differences in effectiveness of cognitive reappraisal found in our study as a function of personality would generalize to different emotion regulation strategies.

Final Conclusions

In summary, we supported our hypotheses that people high in conscientiousness and high in openness to experience were more successful in utilizing cognitive reappraisal to downregulate negative affect following recall of a traumatic memory. This suggests that although reappraisal can be an effective approach for many individuals, it may be less advantageous for persons with particular personality profiles. By considering the versatility of personality, the most efficacious interventions for coping with negative emotions associated with trauma can be identified.

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